What Is Democracy?

Democracy is a system where power rests with the people[1]. Citizens either participate directly in decision-making or elect representatives to do so on their behalf[2]. Key principles include **political equality**, **rule of law**, **protection of fundamental rights**, and **accountability**[3]. It's not just a form of government but a political culture based on freedom, fairness, and participation[4].

There are three main types of democracy:

- **Direct Democracy**: People directly vote on laws and decisions, which is now rare and mostly exists in small communities or through referendums[5].
- **Representative Democracy**: People elect representatives to make decisions for them[6]. This is the most common form today, and it is practiced in Pakistan[7].
- **Social Democracy**: A form of representative democracy that focuses on social justice and equal opportunities through welfare policies[8]. The text argues that many of Pakistan's democratic failures are linked to the absence of social democracy, as political rights are not enough without access to education, healthcare, and economic opportunities[9]. Without social equality, democracy can be dominated by elites[10101010].

Historical Overview of Democracy in Pakistan 📜

- **Early Years (1947–1951)**: Pakistan began as a new state with a weak administrative and institutional base[11]. Muhammad Ali Jinnah, the first Governor-General, emphasized democracy but his death in 1948 created a political vacuum[12]. His successor, Liaquat Ali Khan, passed the Objectives Resolution in 1949 to provide a constitutional direction[13]. However, his assassination in 1951 led to a period of frequent leadership changes, with a series of prime ministers who couldn't complete a full term[14].
- **Military Rule and Instability (1950s–1970)**: Weak political parties, personal rivalries, and growing regional tensions led to political instability[151515151515151515]. The bureaucracy and military became more powerful and saw themselves as "saviors of the state," which paved the way for military intervention[16]. In 1958, Iskander Mirza declared martial law, bringing General Ayub Khan to power[17]. Ayub justified his takeover by citing the failure of politicians, banned political parties, and abrogated

the constitution[18]. He introduced a new constitution in 1962 that centralized power in the president's hands, weakening representative democracy[19191919].

- **The Bhutto Era (1971–1977)**: After the separation of East Pakistan in 1971, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto took charge[20]. His government's key achievement was the **1973 Constitution**, which restored the parliamentary system, guaranteed fundamental rights, and provided for provincial autonomy[21]. Despite this, his government was criticized for suppressing political opponents and limiting press freedom[22]. The 1977 general elections were alleged to be rigged, leading to widespread protests and a political deadlock[23]. This led to another military coup by General Zia-ul-Haq[24].
- **The Zia-ul-Haq Era (1977–1988)**: General Zia-ul-Haq's rule was marked by a deliberate effort to weaken democratic institutions and concentrate power[25]. Political parties were banned, and many leaders were arrested[26]. Zia introduced the Eighth Amendment in 1985, which gave the President the power to dismiss elected governments, significantly weakening parliamentary democracy[27].
- **The Decade of Democracy (1988–1999)**: Following Zia's death, a period of civilian rule began[28]. Benazir Bhutto became the first woman prime minister of a Muslim country[29]. This decade was marked by political instability and constant infighting between her Pakistan People's Party (PPP) and Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N)[30]. Both leaders were dismissed from power multiple times on charges of corruption and mismanagement[31313131]. This period ended in 1999 when General Pervez Musharraf overthrew Nawaz Sharif in another military coup[32].

Reasons for the Failure of Democracy in Pakistan 🤔

Several factors have contributed to the struggle for democracy in Pakistan:

- **Weak Political Parties**: Parties are often built around personalities rather than strong institutions or ideologies[33]. They lack internal democracy, making them unprepared to govern effectively and vulnerable to manipulation[34343434].
- **Absence of a Vibrant Civil Society**: A strong civil society—including independent media, labor unions, and NGOs—is crucial for holding governments accountable[35]. In Pakistan, civil society has been weak, fragmented, or suppressed by decades of military rule and instability[36].
- **Lack of Social Democracy**: Economic inequality means that a large portion of the population doesn't feel the benefits of democracy, as voting doesn't improve their living conditions[37]. This causes people to lose faith in the system[38].

- **Elitist Politics**: Politics has been dominated by a small elite—landowners and wealthy businessmen—who use power to protect their own interests[39]. This limits participation for ordinary citizens and keeps democracy "hollow"[40404040].
- **Bureaucratic and Military Influence**: Both the military and bureaucracy have historically been powerful institutions, often overshadowing elected governments[41]. The military has intervened through coups and exercised indirect influence, creating a perception that they are more capable of running the country than politicians[42424242].
- **Judicialization of Politics**: The judiciary has often overstepped its traditional role, using the "Doctrine of Necessity" to validate military takeovers and striking down executive actions[43]. Political actors also contribute by taking their disputes to court, which enhances the judiciary's power at the expense of parliamentary supremacy[44].

The Future of Democracy in Pakistan

The future of democracy in Pakistan is uncertain but has shown resilience[45454545]. Civilian governments have consistently returned through elections, proving that the democratic spirit is alive[46]. For democracy to succeed, political parties must reform themselves, becoming more democratic internally and focused on public service rather than personal power[47].

The country's future relies on two key principles:

- **Constitutionalism**: All institutions and leaders must operate strictly within the limits set by the constitution[48484848].
- **Constitutional Supremacy**: The constitution must remain the highest authority, above all individuals and institutions[49]. This requires a culture where the military remains under civilian control[50].

Additionally,

political tolerance is essential[51]. Political parties need to "agree to disagree" and engage in constructive dialogue instead of personal attacks and infighting[52]. This principle, combined with the concept of

Rousseau's "collective will"—where different views are harmonized to serve the common good—can help create a more stable and cohesive society[53535353].